

Maria's Notebook

User Guide for Teachers

*A complete guide to managing your
Montessori classroom*

March 2026

What's Inside:

- Students & Profiles
- Lesson Library & Presentations
- Work Tracking & Practice
- Observations & Notes
- Attendance & Scheduling
- Planning & Curriculum Progression
- AI-Powered Insights
- Backup & iCloud Sync

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Getting Started

First Launch

When you open Maria's Notebook for the first time, you'll see a four-page welcome walkthrough:

1. **Welcome** — An overview of what the app does: manage students, lessons, work, and observations all in one place.
2. **Add Your Students** — A reminder to start by adding your students. You can organize them by level and track their lesson history.
3. **Plan Your Lessons** — An introduction to the lesson library and the work lifecycle (active, review, complete).
4. **Quick Notes & More** — How to use the floating button for fast access to notes, presentations, work items, and to-dos.

Tap **Next** to move through each page, or tap **Skip** to jump straight into the app. On the last page, tap **Get Started** to begin.

The Main Screen

After setup, you'll land on the **Today** view — your daily dashboard. Along the top of the screen you'll see navigation pills for the main areas of the app:

Tab	What it does
Today	Your daily hub — lessons, work, reminders, attendance
Attendance	Mark students present, tardy, or absent
Note	Quick observation entry
Students	Your student roster and profiles
Supplies	Classroom inventory
Procedures	Documented classroom routines
Meetings	Student meeting scheduler
Lessons	Your full lesson library

Tab	What it does
More	Access to planning tools, projects, AI chat, settings, and everything else

The Floating Button

In the bottom-right corner of every screen, you'll see a small glass-style button. This is your **quick action hub** — the fastest way to do almost anything in the app.

Gesture	What happens
Double-tap	Opens the Command Bar (type a command in plain English)
Long-press (hold for about half a second)	Opens the Pie Menu with five quick actions
Drag	Moves the button to a new position on screen (it stays where you put it)

The Pie Menu

When you long-press the floating button, five colored segments fan out in a circle:

Segment	Color	What it does
Present	Blue	Record or schedule a lesson presentation
Work	Orange	Create a new work item
Practice	Pink	Log a practice session
Todo	Green	Add a to-do for yourself
Note	Purple	Write a quick observation

Slide your finger to the action you want and release.

The Command Bar

Double-tap the floating button to open a text field where you can type commands in plain English:

- "Gave Sophia long division" — records a presentation
- "Note about Emma's counting — struggling with teen numbers" — creates an observation note

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- "Todo: buy more bead bars by Friday" — creates a to-do with a due date
 - "Assign counting work to Leo" — creates a work item

The app parses your words, identifies students and lessons by name, and fills in the details. You'll see a confirmation before anything is saved.

Today View

The Today view is your daily command center. Everything you need for the current day is here.

Navigating Dates

At the top, you'll see today's date with arrow buttons on either side. Tap the arrows to move forward or back one school day (weekends and holidays you've marked as non-school days are automatically skipped).

Sections

The Today view is organized into collapsible sections. From top to bottom:

Attendance Strip

A quick row of student indicators showing who's present, absent, or not yet marked. Tap to expand the full attendance grid.

Reminders

Any reminders due today or overdue from previous days.

Lessons Due

Presentations you've scheduled for today. Tap a lesson to open it, view the lesson plan, and mark it as given.

Meetings

Student meetings scheduled for today. Tap to open the meeting and record notes.

Scheduled Check-Ins

Work items with check-ins due today. Tap to log your observation.

Todos

Your to-do items for today. Tap the checkbox to mark them complete.

Completed Items

A collapsed section at the bottom showing everything you've finished today — completed work, given lessons, and finished meetings. Useful for reviewing your day.



Students

Viewing Your Roster

Tap **Students** in the navigation to see your full student list. Each student card shows their name, level (Lower or Upper Elementary), and a summary of their recent activity.

You can sort the list by:

- Alphabetical order
- Last lesson given
- Age or grade level
- Upcoming birthdays

Use the search bar at the top to find a student quickly.

Adding a Student

Tap the **Add Student** button (or use the add icon). Fill in:

- **First Name** (required)
- **Last Name** (required)
- **Nickname** (optional — used for display if set)
- **Birthday** (date picker)
- **Start Date** (when the student joined your class)
- **Level** — Lower Elementary or Upper Elementary

Tap **Add** and the student appears in your roster immediately.

Student Detail View

Tap any student to open their full profile. You'll see several tabs:

Progress Tab

An overview of where this student stands across the curriculum. Shows lesson completion by subject and group, with visual indicators for active work, items in review, and mastered lessons.

Meetings Tab

All one-on-one meetings with this student. You can schedule new meetings, view past meeting notes, and track outcomes.

Notes Tab

A timeline of every observation you've recorded for this student. Filter by category (Academic, Behavioral, Social, Emotional, Health, General) or search by text. Newest notes appear first.

Files Tab

Documents attached to this student's profile — report cards, assessments, photos of work samples. Tap to view or add new files.

Lessons

The Lesson Library

Tap **Lessons** to browse your curriculum. Lessons are organized hierarchically:

- **Subjects** (e.g., Math, Language, Science, Practical Life, Sensorial)
- **Groups** within each subject (e.g., "Counting," "Phonics," "Botany")
- **Individual lessons** in each group

You can search by lesson name, filter by subject, or scroll through the full library.

Lesson Detail

Tap any lesson to see its full details:

Section	What it shows
Name & Subject	Title, subject, and group
Write-Up	The full lesson plan and presentation script
Materials	What you need to have ready
Purpose	The educational objective
Age Range	Recommended student ages
Teacher Notes	Your personal notes about teaching this lesson
Follow-Up Work	Suggested activities for after the presentation
Attachments	PDF files, images, or Pages documents
Lesson Journey	A timeline showing which students have received this lesson and their progress

Adding a Lesson

Tap the add button from the Lessons screen. Fill in:

- **Name** (required)
- **Subject** (required — choose from existing subjects or create a new one)

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- **Group** (required — choose from existing groups or create a new one)
 - **Format** — Standard (a regular lesson) or Story (a lesson with parent-child branching for narrative-based curriculum)
 - **Source** — Album (from your Montessori album), Personal (your own lesson), or Great Lesson
 - **Materials, Purpose, Age Range, Teacher Notes, Suggested Follow-Up Work** (all optional but recommended)

You can also **import lessons from a CSV file** for bulk entry — useful when setting up your library for the first time.

Story-Format Lessons

If you choose the Story format, you can create branching lessons: a parent story with child chapters that extend it. This is useful for cosmic education and narrative-based Montessori curriculum where one Great Lesson branches into many follow-up explorations.

Presentations

A **presentation** is the act of giving a lesson to one or more students. This is how you track what you've taught and to whom.

Recording a Presentation

There are several ways to record a presentation:

1. **From the Pie Menu** — Long-press the floating button, select the blue "Present" segment
2. **From a Lesson** — Open a lesson's detail view and tap "Give Lesson" or "Assign"
3. **From the Today View** — Tap a scheduled lesson to open and record it
4. **From the Command Bar** — Type something like "Gave Emma long division"

The Presentation Form

When you create a presentation, you'll fill in:

Lesson

Choose which lesson you're presenting. You can search by name or browse by subject.

Students

Select one or more students who will receive this lesson. You can search by name and select multiple students.

Date

By default, the date is set to today. You can:

- **Mark as Given** — Record it as already presented (today or a past date)
- **Schedule for Later** — Set a future date when you plan to give the lesson

Notes

Free-form text for recording how the presentation went — what the student responded to, what was difficult, any observations.

Follow-Up Options

After recording a presentation, you can set flags:

- **Needs Practice** — The student should practice this independently
- **Needs Another Presentation** — You need to re-present this lesson

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- **Follow-Up Work** — Describe what follow-up activity the student should do

These flags feed into the Inbox, so you'll be reminded to follow up.

Presentation States

Each presentation moves through a lifecycle:

State	Meaning
Draft	Created but not yet scheduled or given
Scheduled	Assigned to a specific future date
Presented	Lesson has been given — this becomes a permanent historical record

Once a presentation is marked as "Presented," the lesson title and details are frozen as a snapshot. Even if you later edit the lesson, the historical record of what you presented remains unchanged.

Work

Work represents the independent practice and follow-up activities students do after receiving a lesson. Work items track a student's progress from initial assignment through mastery.

How Work Gets Created

Work items are typically created:

- **After a presentation** — When you record giving a lesson and check "Needs Practice" or describe follow-up work
- **Manually** — From the Pie Menu (orange "Work" segment) or the Command Bar
- **From the Inbox** — When follow-up recommendations appear and you act on them

Work Detail

Each work item shows:

- **Title** — The name of the work (often matching the lesson name)
- **Student(s)** — Who is assigned
- **Lesson** — The lesson this work relates to
- **Status** — Active, Review, or Complete
- **Due Date** — When you expect the work to be finished (optional)
- **Steps** — A breakdown of the work into individual steps (optional)
- **Check-Ins** — Your observations recorded during the work period
- **Notes** — Any observations attached to this work item

The Work Lifecycle

Active → Review → Complete

Status	What it means
Active	The student is currently working on this
Review	The student may be ready — you need to assess
Complete	The student has finished — record the outcome

When you mark work as complete, you can record a **completion outcome**: mastered, needs review, or needs more practice. This informs the curriculum progression tracking.

Check-Ins

A check-in is a quick observation you record while a student is working. To log one:

1. Open the work item
2. Tap "Add Check-In"
3. Write your observation (what you saw, how the student is progressing)
4. Optionally rate the quality
5. Optionally schedule the next check-in

Check-ins build a timeline of progress for each work item.

Practice Sessions

A **practice session** is a quick log of students practicing during work time. You can record:

- Which students were practicing
- Which work item(s) they were on
- Duration
- Whether it was individual or group practice
- Quality observations

Access this from the Pie Menu (pink "Practice" segment).

Attendance

Daily Attendance

Tap **Attendance** in the navigation to open the daily attendance grid. You'll see all your students listed with status indicators:

Status	Color	Meaning
Present	Green	Student is here
Absent	Red	Student is not here
Tardy	Yellow	Student arrived late
Not marked	Gray	Not yet recorded

Tap a student's indicator to cycle through statuses. There's a **Mark All Present** button for quick entry on days when everyone is here.

Attendance in Today View

The Today view includes an attendance strip at the top — a quick visual showing who's present. Tap to expand the full attendance grid without leaving the Today view.

Attendance History

In each student's detail view, you can see their attendance calendar — a month view showing which days they were present, absent, or tardy. This is useful for parent conferences and tracking patterns.

Notes & Observations

Notes are the primary way to capture classroom observations. You can attach them to specific students, link them to lessons, and categorize them for later reference.

Creating a Note

From the Pie Menu

Long-press the floating button and select the purple "Note" segment. A quick note sheet opens with:

- **Student(s)** — Select one or more students (or "All Students" for a general classroom observation)
- **Body** — Your observation text
- **Tags** — Optional labels for categorization
- **Date** — Defaults to now, but you can change it
- **Photo** — Attach a picture (optional)

From the Command Bar

Type something like:

- "Note about Emma — great focus during counting today"
- "Observation: Leo helped a younger student with practical life"

From a Student's Profile

Open the student's detail view, go to the Notes tab, and tap the add button.

Note Scope

Each note can be scoped to:

- **All students** — A general classroom observation
- **One student** — Specific to that child
- **Multiple students** — An observation about a group interaction

Tags and Categories

Notes can be tagged with custom labels. Common categories include Academic, Behavioral, Social, Emotional, Health, and General. You can create your own tags in Settings.

Viewing Notes

Notes appear in several places:

- **Student detail view** — Notes tab shows all observations for that student
- **Today view** — Recent notes from today
- **Notes section** (from the navigation) — Search and filter across all notes

Note Templates

In Settings, you can create templates — pre-written observation starters that save time during busy classroom moments. Templates can include default tags and category settings.

Todos

Todos are your personal task list — things you need to do that aren't directly student work items.

Creating a Todo

From the Pie Menu (green "Todo" segment) or the Command Bar:

- **Title** (required) — What you need to do
- **Description** (optional) — Additional details
- **Due Date** (optional) — When it's due
- **Recurrence** — None, Daily, Weekdays, Weekly, Biweekly, Monthly, Yearly, or Custom
- **Subtasks** — Break the todo into smaller steps

Smart Parsing

The Command Bar understands natural language for todos:

- "Buy bead bars by Friday" — Creates a todo with title "Buy bead bars" and due date set to Friday
- "Finish report daily" — Creates a recurring daily todo
- "Remind me to call Emma's parents" — Creates a todo titled "Call Emma's parents"

Todos in Today View

Your incomplete todos for today appear in a dedicated section. Tap the checkbox to mark them complete. Recurring todos automatically generate the next occurrence.

Subtasks

Complex todos can have subtasks — a checklist within the todo. Check off each subtask as you complete it. The parent todo tracks how many subtasks are done.

Supplies

Track your classroom materials and inventory so you always know what you have and what needs restocking.

Supplies List

Tap **Supplies** in the navigation to see all your tracked materials. Each supply shows:

- Name
- Status badge — **In Stock** (green), **Low** (yellow), **Critical** (orange), or **Out of Stock** (red)
- Category and location

Adding a Supply

Tap the add button and fill in:

- **Name** (required) — e.g., "Colored Pencils"
- **Category** (required) — Materials, Books, Equipment, Consumables, Art Supplies, Food, or Other
- **Current Quantity** — How many you have now
- **Minimum Threshold** — The quantity at which the status switches to "Low"
- **Reorder Amount** — How many to order when restocking
- **Location** — Where it's stored in your classroom
- **Notes** — Any additional information

Managing Inventory

From a supply's detail view, you can:

- **Adjust quantity** — Add or remove stock
- **Mark as on order** — Flag that you've ordered more
- **View transaction history** — See all additions and removals over time

The status automatically updates based on your current quantity versus the minimum threshold.

Procedures

Document your classroom procedures and routines so you have them in one place — useful for substitutes, assistants, and your own reference.

Adding a Procedure

Tap the add button from the Procedures screen:

- **Title** (required) — e.g., "Morning Arrival Routine"
- **Category** — Classroom Management, Practical Life, Transitions, Grace & Courtesy, Academic, or Other
- **Steps** — The step-by-step procedure
- **Materials** — What's needed
- **Age Group** — Which students this applies to
- **Notes** — Teaching tips or reminders

Procedures are searchable and filterable by category.

Planning Tools

Tap **More** in the navigation to access the full set of planning tools.

Open Work

A view of all active work items across all students. Filter by student, subject, or status. Use this to plan which students need check-ins and what work needs attention.

Checklist

A class-wide checklist view organized by subject and group. See at a glance which students have received which lessons. Check off items as you go — useful for weekly or monthly planning.

Progress Dashboard

A per-student progression map across the curriculum. Each student's card shows where they stand by subject area; tap a category to open the sequence detail — what's been presented, what's mastered, and what comes next.

Inbox

The Inbox is your follow-up assistant. It automatically collects items that need your attention and organizes them by urgency.

How Items Get Into the Inbox

- Presentations marked "Needs Practice" or "Needs Another Presentation"
- Work items that haven't had a check-in recently
- Work items in "Review" status that haven't been completed
- Overdue scheduled items

Inbox Buckets

Bucket	What it means
Overdue	Items that have gone too long without attention (lessons >7 days, work >5 days, reviews >3 days)
Due Today	Items scheduled for today
Inbox	Items needing action but not yet overdue
Upcoming	Items scheduled for the future

Acting on Inbox Items

Tap any item to open it. From there you can:

- Schedule a check-in
 - Mark work as complete
 - Re-present a lesson
 - Reschedule for later
 - Dismiss if no longer relevant
-

Projects

Track long-term student projects, research initiatives, and independent studies.

Creating a Project

Tap the add button from the Projects screen:

- **Title** — The project name
- **Description** — What the project is about
- **Students** — Select participating students
- **Start and End Dates** — Or mark as "ongoing"
- **Roles** — Define responsibilities (e.g., "Lead Researcher," "Scribe," "Presenter")

Project Weeks

For multi-week projects, you can define a week-by-week structure. Each week has:

- Role assignments (which student has which responsibility)
- Goals for that week
- Notes

Project Sessions

Log individual work sessions:

- Date and students present
 - What was accomplished
 - Notes and observations
 - Deliverables
-

Tracks

A **track** is a defined curriculum path — a sequence of lessons and skills a student moves through over time. Tracks help you ensure students progress systematically.

Setting Up Tracks

When creating a track, you define:

- Track name (e.g., "Math: Counting to Multiplication")
- Steps — The ordered sequence of lessons or milestones
- Which students are enrolled

Monitoring Progress

The Progress Dashboard and each student's Progress tab show the student's position in their enrolled tracks. You can see who's ahead, who's on pace, and who may need additional support.

Group Tracks

Group tracks let you apply the same progression template to multiple students at once, while still tracking individual progress.

Meetings

Schedule and record one-on-one meetings with students.

Scheduling a Meeting

From the Meetings tab or a student's profile:

- **Student** (required)
- **Date and Time**
- **Duration** (optional)
- **Purpose** (optional) — What you plan to discuss
- **Notes** — Pre-meeting preparation notes

Scheduled meetings appear in your Today view on the scheduled date.

During a Meeting

Open the meeting to record:

- Observations and discussion points
- Outcomes and next steps
- Follow-up actions

Meeting Templates

Create templates in Settings for common meeting types (e.g., "Progress Check," "Behavior Discussion," "Parent Follow-Up") with pre-filled purpose and note starters.

AI Assistant

Maria's Notebook includes an AI chat feature powered by Claude. It can analyze your classroom data and answer questions.

Setup

Before using AI features, you need to add your Anthropic API key:

1. Go to **Settings**
2. Find the **AI / Chat** section
3. Enter your API key
4. Choose your preferred model (Claude 3 Opus for best quality, Sonnet for balanced, Haiku for fastest)

What You Can Ask

The AI has access to your classroom data and can answer questions like:

- "Which students haven't received a lesson in the past two weeks?"
- "Summarize Emma's progress this month"
- "What's my curriculum balance across subjects?"
- "Which work items are overdue?"
- "Help me plan next week's lessons"
- "Generate a progress summary for parent conferences"

How to Access

Tap **Ask AI** from the More menu. You'll see a chat interface where you can type questions and receive responses. The AI reads your actual student, lesson, and work data to give relevant answers.

Backup & Restore

Protect your data by creating regular backups.

Creating a Backup

1. Go to **Settings**
2. Tap **Backup & Restore**
3. Tap **Create Backup**
4. Choose where to save the file (Files app, iCloud Drive, or local storage)
5. Optionally set a password to encrypt the backup
6. A confirmation toast appears when the backup is complete

The backup file is a JSON document containing all your students, lessons, presentations, work items, notes, and settings.

Restoring from a Backup

1. Go to **Settings**
2. Tap **Backup & Restore**
3. Tap **Restore from Backup**
4. Select your backup file
5. Choose restore mode:
 - **Merge** — Adds missing data from the backup while keeping your current data
 - **Replace** — Replaces all current data with the backup contents
6. Wait for the restore to complete (a progress bar shows status)

iCloud Sync

If you enable CloudKit in Settings, your data automatically syncs across your devices via iCloud. This is separate from manual backups — it happens continuously in the background.

Settings

Access Settings from the **More** menu. Here's what you can configure:

Classroom Setup

- School name
- Grade levels and age groups
- School year start and end dates
- School day schedule

Calendar

- Mark non-school days (holidays, breaks, professional development)
- Override specific dates (e.g., make a Saturday a school day)
- Sync with your system calendar to display events

Reminders (macOS)

- Two-way sync with the macOS Reminders app
- Reminders created in the app appear in your system Reminders, and vice versa

Note Templates

- Create custom observation templates
- Pre-written starters for common observations
- Default tags and categories

Meeting Templates

- Templates for common meeting types
- Pre-filled purpose and note fields

AI / Chat

- Anthropic API key

-
- Model selection (Opus, Sonnet, Haiku)
 - API usage statistics

CloudKit Sync

- Enable or disable iCloud sync
- View sync status and health
- Manually trigger sync or resolve conflicts

Backup & Restore

- Create and restore backups
- Configure auto-backup frequency
- Manage cloud backups

Data Management

- View database statistics (number of students, lessons, notes, etc.)
 - Export data
 - Import data from CSV
 - Run integrity checks
-

Tips for Daily Use

Start Your Day with Today View

Open the app each morning and check the Today view. It shows everything on your plate — scheduled lessons, pending work check-ins, meetings, reminders, and todos. Use the date arrows to look ahead at tomorrow or review yesterday.

Use the Floating Button Constantly

The Pie Menu and Command Bar are designed for the pace of a real classroom. When you notice something:

- **Long-press** and slide to "Note" to capture an observation in seconds
- **Long-press** and slide to "Practice" to log what students are working on
- **Double-tap** and type a quick command like "Gave Leo botany"

Let the Inbox Guide Your Follow-Ups

Don't try to remember every follow-up. When you record a presentation with "Needs Practice" or describe follow-up work, the Inbox automatically tracks it and reminds you when it's time to check in.

Use Check-Ins to Build a Progress Story

Every time you observe a student working, log a quick check-in on their work item. Over time, these build a detailed picture of each student's journey — invaluable for parent conferences and progress reports.

Review Progress Weekly

Set aside time each week (perhaps Friday afternoon) to open the Progress Dashboard and see where each student stands. This helps you plan the next week's presentations and ensures no student falls behind.

Back Up Regularly

Create a manual backup at least once a week, or enable auto-backup in Settings. Your classroom data is irreplaceable — protect it.

Gestures & Shortcuts Quick Reference

iOS

Gesture	Where	What it does
Long-press floating button	Any screen	Opens Pie Menu
Double-tap floating button	Any screen	Opens Command Bar
Drag floating button	Any screen	Repositions it
Tap date arrows	Today view	Navigate between school days
Tap student card	Students list	Opens student detail
Tap lesson card	Lessons list	Opens lesson detail

macOS

Shortcut	What it does
Cmd+N	New item (context-dependent)
Cmd+S	Save
Cmd+,	Open Settings

Glossary

Term	What it means
Presentation	The act of teaching a lesson to a student — the Montessori term for giving a lesson
Work	Independent practice or follow-up activity a student does after receiving a presentation
Check-In	A teacher's observation recorded while a student is working
Track	A defined curriculum progression path — a sequence of lessons or skills
Great Lesson	One of the five foundational Montessori cosmic education stories
Album	A Montessori teacher's collection of lesson plans, organized by subject
Three-Period Lesson	A Montessori teaching method: naming (period 1), recognition (period 2), recall (period 3)
Scope	Who a note applies to — all students, one student, or a selected group
Pie Menu	The circular quick-action menu that appears when you long-press the floating button
Command Bar	The natural-language text input for typing commands in plain English
Inbox	The automatic follow-up tracker that collects items needing your attention
Mastery	When a student demonstrates proficiency in a lesson or skill